

HALF A MILLION IN BLACK FRIDAY SALES. THE MARGINS WERE GONE BY JANUARY.

The 5 numbers and the
12-week plan we use
now.



LEIGHTON PENROSE

Co-Owner, Leading Social



A few years ago one of our clients had a huge Black Friday.

**ABOUT HALF A
MILLION IN SALES
IN JUST A FEW
DAYS.**

They celebrated, and to be honest we thought it was great too.



**THEN JANUARY
CAME.**

WHEN WE REVIEWED IT IN JANUARY, **THE MARGINS WERE GONE.**

25%

SITEWIDE DISCOUNT

They had run a sitewide 25% discount with:

- ☒ no contribution margin tracked
- ☒ no CAC target set
- ☒ and spend scaled fast with nothing protecting the profit

Half a million in sales, and the money just wasn't really being made.

THAT ONE WAS ON US AS WELL.

I think it was 2021. Back then we made the creative and ran the ads. We had no sight of the client's figures, and we never asked for them.

Since then we've put the financial side in place, so that doesn't happen again.



The first change was the numbers. Before anyone touches creative or campaigns, **five of them go on paper:**

01

REVENUE GOAL

What's the Black Friday revenue goal?

02

CUSTOMERS NEEDED

How many customers do you need to hit it?

03

TARGET CAC

What's your target CAC?

04

BREAK-EVEN

Where's your break-even point?

05

MER FLOOR

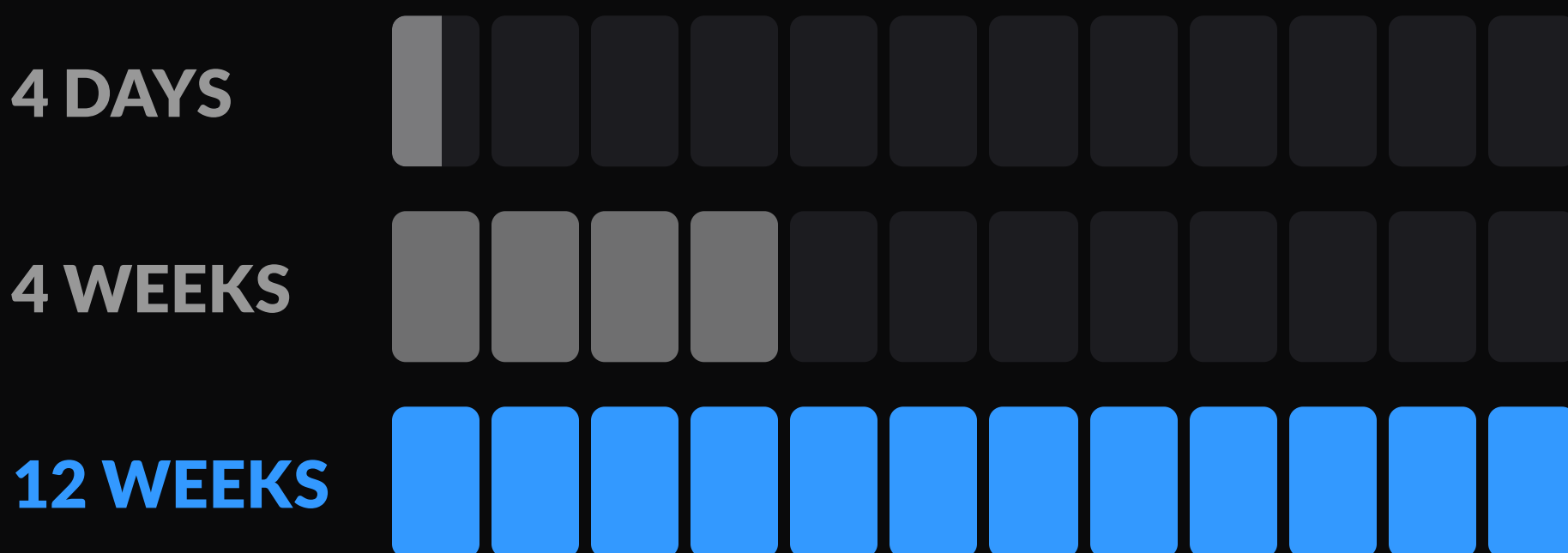
What's your MER floor?

We also get much more involved in the offer and the product COGS, to make sure everything is profitable.

THE SECOND CHANGE WAS THE CALENDAR.

A lot of brands treat Black Friday like a four-day sprint, or a crazy four weeks in November.

With our clients we run it as a 12-week campaign.



The 12 weeks break down like this.

THE 12-WEEK TIMELINE WE RUN WITH CLIENTS

SUMMER AND SEPTEMBER

○ **LEAD GEN AND LIST BUILDING**

OCTOBER **LATE SEPTEMBER? YOU ARE HERE**

● **AUDIENCE WARMING, OFFER TESTING,
CREATIVE TESTING**

EARLY NOVEMBER

○ **VIP EARLY ACCESS AND EXCLUSIVE
BUNDLES**

BLACK FRIDAY WEEK

● **THE MAIN CAMPAIGN**

DECEMBER

○ **SELF-PURCHASE MESSAGING**

If you're reading this in late September, the list-building window is probably closing.

OCTOBER IS STILL FULLY AHEAD OF YOU.

That leaves time for audience warming, offer testing and creative testing.

So the offer and the creative get tested well before the main campaign starts.



Then Black Friday week arrives, and we track it **like any other sales period**:

01

NET SALES

02

MER

03

**NEW CUSTOMERS
AGAINST
RETURNING
CUSTOMERS**

04

**AND NEW
CUSTOMER
ACQUISITION COST**

We'll throw an eye over ROAS on the platforms, and that's about it. To be honest it rarely tells the true story.

For the spend, I pull a brand's last five years of data and work from the averages.

**I put the five numbers and the
12-week timeline into one
planner.**

**COMMENT
“PLANNER”**

and I'll send it to you.



Leighton Penrose
Co-Owner, Leading Social